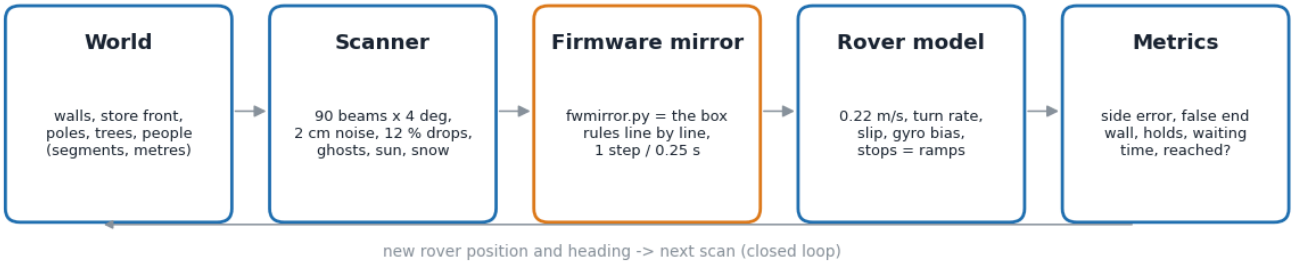
How our Python 2D simulator works

Rover kit 04, box firmware `cas_box_mission` v10.3. Code: `cas_box_mission/tools/`. All numbers are from runs on 9 Nov 2026 or earlier.

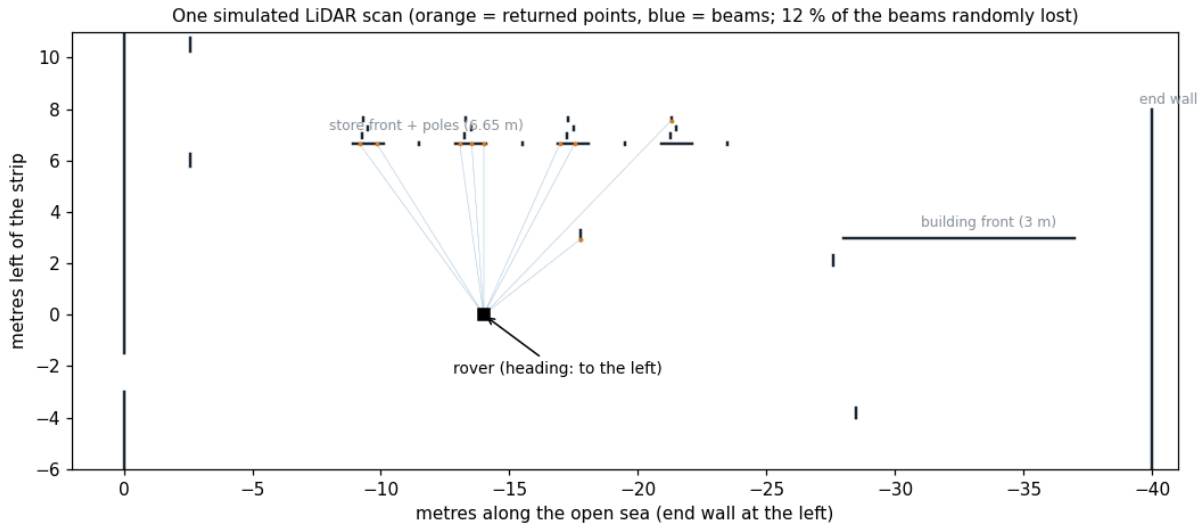
1. What it is, in one paragraph

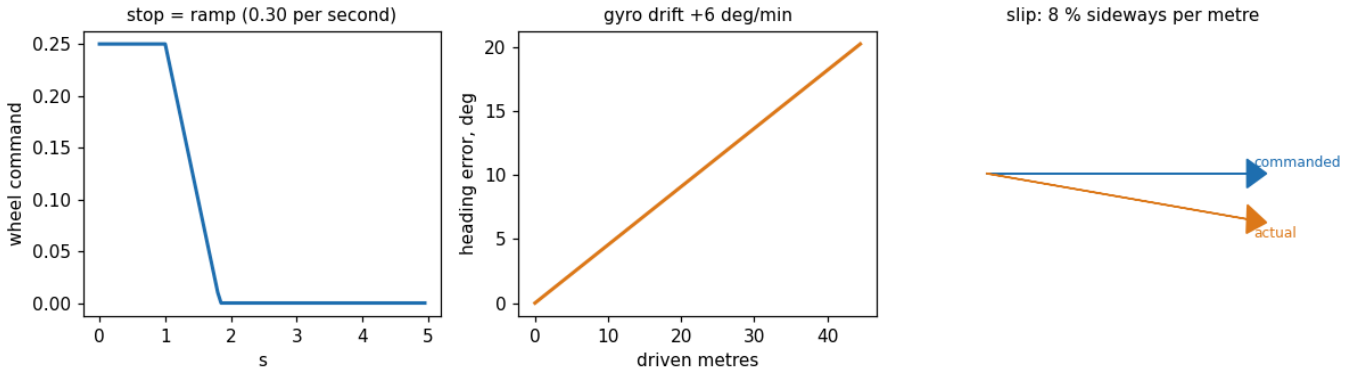
We cannot bring crowds, snow or a hundred different starting positions to the campus on demand, and every field test costs a day. So the box rules were copied, line by line, into Python (`fwmirror.py`), and put into a small closed-loop world: a map in metres, a simulated LiDAR that "sees" that map, and a simple rover that moves according to what the rules decide. One run = one complete crossing, thousands of runs = a table in a minute. It is **our own simulator** (about 1,500 lines of Python, no ROS, no Gazebo): the logic we want to test is ESP32 C++ without ROS, so any other simulator would still need this Python copy of the rules.



2. The five parts

Part	What it does	File / function
World	Segments (lines) in metres: B wall behind, the store front with its two poles and two trees, the building front at 3 m, the end wall at 40 m, people as 0.4 m squares (standing, walking, bouncing). Positions come from the real LiDAR logs (campus_2…c102_4).	`sim_open_sea.py: world(), crowd()`
Scanner	Ray casting: 90 beams, 4° apart, angle `(i·4+2)°` clockwise from the front, the same as the real `LidarScan`. Gaussian noise 2 cm, 12 % of the beams lost, values below 35 cm removed (the real filter). **Weather and sun** are added per scan: daylight ghosts (1–2 beams at 20–34 cm in 15–20 % of scans, measured in campus_6), a blind 40° slice for low sun, snow = every beam has an 8 % chance of a random near return (0.35–3 m) and a 25 % chance of nothing.	`scan(), env_noise()`
Firmware mirror	The decision code: reference order (row, building, B wall, end wall), cross-track PID `10·e + 1.5·∫e + 20·ė` (±8°), the wide / nearest-surface end-wall check with its leaky counter, the people hold rule (0.6 m, 0.5 s), the turn structure detector (`TurnV9`, `StructGrid`), the start alignment (`StartAlign`), the leg-4 ramp-opening finder (`find_gap`). One step per 0.25 s, the same as the box.	`fwmirror.py`, `sim_start_align.py`, `replay_l4_gap.py`
Rover model	Speed 0.22 m/s (leg 4: 0.30), the heading follows the target at about 12°/s (DriveStraight), the gyro drifts (bias ±3 … 6°/min), sideways slip (3–8 % of the distance, a slanted cobblestone), pivots end ±3° off, stops are ramps.	`run(), align()`
Metrics	Side error at 24 m and at the end wall, false end-wall stops (people taken for the wall), holds and waiting time, reached or not.	`batch(), crowd_table(), env_table()`





3. Is it realistic? What was checked

- **Same format as the real scan.** The row appears at the same bearing and range in a real scan of c102_3 and in the simulated scan at the same place.
- **Calibrated on logs:** the row is seen in about half of the scans, as in the real runs (15–25 % in the harder "sparse row" case we also test); ghosts, dropouts and the row distance 6.5–6.8 m come from nine logs.
- **Rules identical to the box:** `tools/replay_.py` *runs the* same* mirror on the real recorded scans of 12 logs and compares with what the box did (first turn, end wall, Open Sea references, start alignment, ramp opening). Example: `replay_end_wall.py` finds the end wall within 0.2 m of where the box really turned in 7 of the 9 runs that ended at the end wall (it misses campus_3 and test2).
- **Honest limits:** it is a model, not the campus. It has no ultrasonic at the walls, no ramp or stairs (the leg-4 ramp opening has its own small geometric sim), no wheel-ground physics, a flat world. A pass in the simulator means "the rule works if the world looks like this"; the field test still decides. Falling snow, for example, makes the end wall unconfirmed in 2 of 12 runs, and a fake straight line 4–9.5 m away (bike rack) can pull the rover 1–2 m off.

4. The scenarios (what we ask the simulator)

Question	Command	Result (v10)
Crowds: do people look like the end wall? 12 scenarios x 20 runs	`python3 sim_open_sea.py --crowd`	person 0.8 m in front of the wall: 9 → 0 of 20 false stops; no crowd case with a false stop
Sun and snow, 12 runs each	`--env`	clear, glare, low sun, snowy ground 12/12; falling snow 10/12; everything at once 7/12

Faults: row missing, gap, B wall hidden, false lines, heading glitches, gyro bias	`--faults --v7only`	missing row / gap / hidden wall: ≤2 cm; false line: 1–2 m
Nearest-surface end-wall rule	`--nearest`	no false end wall in any crowd case
Turn at the right pillar with people around	`python3 sim_people.py`	5,670 cases, 93.3 % on target, 0 wrong pillar
Start alignment after a late turn (v10.3)	`python3 sim_start_align.py`	in-band starts untouched 100/100; late starts (+0.7 … +2.2 m) end 0.06–0.2 m off the strip
Start alignment in snow noise, 25 % dropouts, pivot error 6°, slip 8 %, people	`--stress`	untouched 120/120 in band; 131 of 144 late starts within 0.5 m; 0 of 144 worse. (A first version using the plain nearest point failed here: 13 of 144 worse. The simulator found it before the field did.)
Ramp opening on leg 4	`python3 sim_l4_gap.py`	180 approaches: 0 hits on the stairs

5. How to run it

```
cd cas_box_mission/tools
python3 sim_open_sea.py --crowd       # crowd table (about 1-2 min)
python3 sim_start_align.py --quick    # start alignment, short
python3 replay_turn.py                # real logs through the turn rule
python3 make_sim_doc_figs.py          # redraw the figures of this document
```

Every tool prints a table; nothing writes to the rover or the box.

6. Why not LG SVL, CARLA, RViz, Gazebo or MATLAB?

Tool	Why it is not the core of this work
LG SVL	discontinued in 2022
CARLA	built for cars, roads and traffic; no campus walkways
RViz	a viewer, not a simulator; we use it only to *show* a log (`tools/rviz_replay.py`)
Gazebo / MATLAB	possible, but need a model of the box rules too; our rules are ESP32 C++, so the Python copy would still be needed. Days of work for a nicer picture, not for better proof.